

● PLAYBOOK · 20 CHANNELS · 1 DECISION PAGE

The 20 Marketing Channels Playbook

Every channel an early-stage company is told to "be on", reduced to what actually matters: when it fits, the first three moves, the one number to watch, and the mistake that burns the budget. Written for founders in Web3, AI and cybersecurity, useful for any B2B or developer-facing product.

HOW TO USE THIS PLAYBOOK

1. Scan the overview matrix and cross out every channel your buyer does not use. Be honest.
2. Read the sections for what is left. Note which ones you could start this week with the skills you already have.
3. Use the "Pick 3 by stage" page to choose. Three channels, eight weeks, written kill criteria.
4. Plan the money in the Marketing Budget Template (it has a line for each of the 20 channels).

BEST FOR

Founders choosing where the next dollar and hour go

READING TIME

35 minutes end to end, 2 minutes per channel

A NOTE ON NUMBERS

Costs and timings are operator estimates for early-stage teams. Treat them as starting assumptions, then replace them with your own data.

OVERVIEW

The channel matrix

Cost to start is the minimum to learn something real, not to scale. Time to first result is when you should see a leading signal (replies, qualified visits, citations), not revenue.

#	CHANNEL	COST TO START	TIME TO FIRST RESULT	BEST FOR	SKILL NEEDED
1	SEO	Low cash, high time	3 to 6 months	Problems people already search for	Writing, technical SEO
2	GEO / AI search	Low cash, high time	1 to 3 months	Considered B2B and technical purchases	Writing, schema, PR
3	Google Ads	\$2K to \$5K test	1 to 2 weeks	High-intent, named-category demand	Paid search, landing pages
4	Meta Ads	\$2K to \$5K test	1 to 2 weeks	Consumer, prosumer, retargeting	Creative testing
5	LinkedIn Ads	\$3K to \$8K test	2 to 4 weeks	B2B with high contract value	Targeting, offer design
6	Reddit	Time; ads optional	2 to 6 weeks	Developers, crypto, technical buyers	Genuine participation
7	X / Twitter	Time	2 to 8 weeks	Crypto, AI, developer narrative	Writing, consistency
8	LinkedIn organic	Time	4 to 8 weeks	Founder-led B2B and enterprise	Writing, point of view
9	YouTube	Medium	3 to 6 months	Tutorials, demos, education	Video, scripting
10	TikTok / Shorts	Low to medium	2 to 8 weeks	Consumer, creator tools, hiring brand	Short-form video
11	Email	Low	Immediate	Converting and retaining any audience	Copywriting, segmentation
12	WhatsApp	Low	1 to 4 weeks	India, MENA, LATAM, SE Asia; high-touch sales	Conversational selling
13	Communities	Time	1 to 3 months	Web3, developer tools, open source	Moderation, programming
14	Product Hunt and launch sites	Low	Launch day	Dev tools, AI apps, prosumer SaaS	Launch operations
15	PR / earned media	In-house time, or \$5K to \$12K/mo fractional	4 to 12 weeks	Funding, launches, trust-heavy categories	Angles, relationships
16	Podcasts	Time	1 to 3 months	Founder-led, technical depth	Speaking, pitching
17	Influencers / KOLs	Varies widely	1 to 4 weeks	Crypto, consumer AI, dev tools	Vetting, briefing
18	Partnerships and integrations	Time, some engineering	2 to 6 months	Platforms with ecosystems	BD, product
19	Events and conferences	\$3K to \$50K+ per event	Event week	Enterprise, Web3, security	Planning, follow-up
20	Referral programs	Low plus incentives	1 to 3 months	Products people already recommend	Product, lifecycle

CHANNELS

Owned and search

01 · SEO

LOW CASH · 3 TO 6 MONTHS · DEMAND CAPTURE

WHEN IT FITS	Buyers search for the problem or the category in words you can name today. Your product has a long consideration cycle and buyers research before talking to sales.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. List 30 questions your buyers type, from sales calls and support tickets, not only keyword tools. 2. Fix the technical basics: indexation in Search Console, unique titles, internal links from the homepage to money pages. 3. Publish 4 pages that each answer one high-intent question better than the current top result, with a clear next step.
METRIC TO WATCH	Non-branded organic clicks to pages that lead to a signup or demo, plus signups from those pages.
COMMON MISTAKE	Publishing high-volume top-of-funnel posts ("what is blockchain") that rank for nobody who will ever buy.

02 · GEO / AI search

LOW CASH · 1 TO 3 MONTHS · CITATION

WHEN IT FITS	Your buyers ask ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini or Claude for recommendations ("best smart contract auditors", "AI SOC tools for mid-market"). Increasingly, this is most technical B2B.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Ask 20 buyer questions across four AI assistants and log who gets cited and which sources are linked. 2. Make your entity consistent: same name, description and founder details on your site, LinkedIn, Crunchbase, GitHub and directories. 3. Publish answer-first pages with citable paragraphs and FAQs, and earn mentions on the third-party sources the assistants already cite.
METRIC TO WATCH	Share of the 20 tracked prompts where you are cited or named, checked monthly.
COMMON MISTAKE	Treating it as a technical trick (only adding llms.txt or schema). Assistants mostly repeat what credible third parties say about you.

II · Email

LOW COST · IMMEDIATE · CONVERSION AND RETENTION

WHEN IT FITS	Always, once you have a list. It is the only channel you own end to end and the one that turns launch traffic into users.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Authenticate your sending domain (SPF, DKIM, DMARC) before the first send. 2. Write a 4-email welcome sequence that drives one activation action, not a newsletter archive. 3. Ship a monthly product update to everyone, with one story and one call to action.
METRIC TO WATCH	Click-to-activation rate from the welcome sequence. Open rates are unreliable since mailbox privacy changes.
COMMON MISTAKE	Buying lists or cold emailing from the primary domain, which damages deliverability for every email you send after.

CHANNELS

Paid

03 · Google Ads

\$2K TO \$5K TEST · 1 TO 2 WEEKS · DEMAND CAPTURE

WHEN IT FITS	People already search for your category, a competitor, or the exact problem, and you can afford the click price for that intent.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Start with exact and phrase match on 10 to 20 high-intent terms plus competitor terms. No broad match until conversions are tracked. 2. Build one landing page per intent cluster whose headline matches the search. 3. Import offline conversions (qualified lead, opportunity) from your CRM so bidding optimises for quality.
METRIC TO WATCH	Cost per qualified lead, and search terms report weekly to add negatives.
COMMON MISTAKE	Letting Performance Max or broad match spend the test budget on irrelevant searches before conversion tracking is right. Note: crypto and some financial products need Google certification before ads will serve.

04 · Meta Ads

\$2K TO \$5K TEST · 1 TO 2 WEEKS · DEMAND CREATION

WHEN IT FITS	Consumer, prosumer or creator products, broad audiences, and retargeting site visitors for any product. Weak for narrow enterprise roles.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Install the pixel plus Conversions API so events survive browser restrictions. 2. Produce 6 to 10 creative variations across 3 angles (problem, outcome, social proof). Creative is the targeting now. 3. Run one broad campaign and one retargeting campaign. Keep structure simple so the algorithm can learn.
METRIC TO WATCH	Cost per activated user (not cost per signup), by creative angle.
COMMON MISTAKE	Judging the channel after 3 days or on one creative. Also: crypto ads require prior written permission from Meta in most cases.

05 · LinkedIn Ads

\$3K TO \$8K TEST · 2 TO 4 WEEKS · PRECISE B2B REACH

WHEN IT FITS	Your average contract value is high enough to absorb expensive clicks, and you can describe the buyer by title, function, seniority and company size.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Upload a named-account list (your ICP accounts) and layer job function and seniority. 2. Run Thought Leader Ads that promote the founder's best organic posts. They tend to beat polished brand creative for early-stage companies. 3. Offer something worth a work email: a benchmark, a template, a teardown. Not "book a demo" to cold audiences.
METRIC TO WATCH	Cost per qualified lead from target accounts, and engagement from named accounts.
COMMON MISTAKE	Audiences too broad, budget too thin. Ten dollars a day across five campaigns teaches you nothing.

CHANNELS

Social and communities

06 · Reddit

TIME · 2 TO 6 WEEKS · CREDIBILITY

WHEN IT FITS	There are active subreddits where your buyers ask for advice (developer tools, security, crypto, specific ecosystems). Reddit threads are also frequently cited by AI assistants and Google.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Pick 3 to 5 subreddits and read each subreddit's rules on self-promotion. 2. Have the founder or an engineer answer questions for a month under a real, disclosed identity, with no links unless asked. 3. When you share your own work, share the useful thing (the data, the write-up), and disclose that you built it.
METRIC TO WATCH	Referral sessions and self-reported "Reddit" on signup forms; upvoted helpful comments as a leading signal.
COMMON MISTAKE	Astroturfing with alt accounts or paid upvotes. Communities spot it fast and the thread becomes the top search result about you.

07 · X / Twitter

TIME · 2 TO 8 WEEKS · NARRATIVE

WHEN IT FITS	Crypto, AI and developer audiences where news, launches and arguments still break first on X. Journalists in these beats watch it closely.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Founder account first, company account second. Rewrite the bio to say what you build and for whom. 2. Post daily for 6 weeks: one original insight, the rest replies to the 30 accounts your buyers follow. 3. Turn each launch or data point into a thread with a visual and one clear link at the end.
METRIC TO WATCH	Profile visits and follows from your target audience; inbound DMs from buyers, partners or press.
COMMON MISTAKE	Engagement-bait and giveaway follows that inflate counts with accounts that will never buy or cover you.

08 · LinkedIn organic

TIME · 4 TO 8 WEEKS · FOUNDER-LED TRUST

WHEN IT FITS	B2B, enterprise, security and AI infrastructure, where buyers, investors and hires all check the founder's profile before replying.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Fix the founder profile: headline that names the customer and outcome, featured section with the best proof. 2. Post 3 times a week using the 30-Day Founder Content Calendar. Lessons, opinions with evidence, behind-the-scenes. 3. Spend 20 minutes a day leaving substantive comments on posts by target buyers.
METRIC TO WATCH	Profile views from ICP titles and inbound conversations started, not likes.
COMMON MISTAKE	Company-page-only posting. People follow people; company pages get a fraction of the reach.

13 · Communities (Discord, Slack, Telegram)

TIME · 1 TO 3 MONTHS · RETENTION AND ADVOCACY

WHEN IT FITS	Your users benefit from talking to each other: developer tools, open source, protocols, Web3 products with token holders. Not every SaaS needs its own community.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Pick one platform where your users already are. Telegram for many crypto audiences, Discord for developers and gaming, Slack for B2B practitioners. 2. Seed it with 30 to 50 real users before announcing it, and run a weekly programme (office hours, changelog, AMA). 3. Lock down security: verified admin roles, no DMs from staff by default, pinned anti-scam notice.
METRIC TO WATCH	Weekly active members who post, and questions answered by members instead of staff.
COMMON MISTAKE	Launching an empty server, or counting members inflated by airdrop hunters as community.

CHANNELS

Video and messaging

09 · YouTube

MEDIUM · 3 TO 6 MONTHS · EDUCATION AND SEARCH

WHEN IT FITS	Your product needs showing, not telling, and buyers look for tutorials, comparisons and walkthroughs. YouTube is also the second-largest search surface and is cited by AI assistants.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Record 5 videos that answer the most common "how do I" questions from support and sales. 2. Write titles the way people search them, and add chapters and a full transcript. 3. Embed each video on the matching docs or blog page.
METRIC TO WATCH	Average view duration on tutorial videos and clicks to your site from descriptions.
COMMON MISTAKE	Uploading webinar recordings with no edit and calling it a channel.

10 · TikTok / Shorts / Reels

LOW TO MEDIUM · 2 TO 8 WEEKS · REACH

WHEN IT FITS	Consumer products, consumer AI apps, creator tools, and employer brand. Works for B2B only when a founder is genuinely good on camera.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Watch 50 videos in your niche and note the formats that hold attention in the first 2 seconds. 2. Batch-record 12 videos in one session: hook, one idea, one visual payoff, under 45 seconds. 3. Post the same cuts to TikTok, YouTube Shorts and Instagram Reels and keep what travels.
METRIC TO WATCH	Average watch time and share rate per video; profile clicks.
COMMON MISTAKE	Repurposing polished ads into the feed. Native, lo-fi and specific outperforms brand-safe and generic.

12 · WhatsApp

LOW · 1 TO 4 WEEKS · HIGH-TOUCH NURTURE

WHEN IT FITS	Your buyers live on WhatsApp for business: India, the Gulf, LATAM, Africa and much of Southeast Asia. Strong for event follow-up, community broadcasts and founder-led sales.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Set up WhatsApp Business with a verified profile, catalogue or service list, and quick replies. 2. Collect explicit opt-in (event QR codes, website click-to-chat). Never add people to groups without consent. 3. Use a Channel or broadcast list for updates and keep 1:1 chats for sales conversations.
METRIC TO WATCH	Reply rate and meetings booked from WhatsApp conversations.
COMMON MISTAKE	Treating it like email blast. Frequent unsolicited messages get you reported and restricted.

14 · Product Hunt and launch sites

LOW · LAUNCH DAY · SPIKE AND BACKLINKS

WHEN IT FITS	Developer tools, AI apps and prosumer SaaS with a self-serve signup. Less useful for enterprise-only or token launches.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Prepare assets 2 weeks out: tagline, gallery, 60-second video, maker's first comment with the story and an offer. 2. Tell your existing users and community the day before, and ask for honest feedback rather than upvotes. 3. Cross-post the same week to Show HN (if technical), BetaList, relevant subreddits and niche directories.
METRIC TO WATCH	Signups and activated users from launch traffic, not the leaderboard rank.
COMMON MISTAKE	Asking for upvotes in mass DMs or vote rings. It breaks platform rules and can get the launch penalised.

CHANNELS

Earned and borrowed attention

15 · PR / earned media

TIME OR \$5K TO \$12K/MO · 4 TO 12 WEEKS · CREDIBILITY

WHEN IT FITS	You have real news (funding, launch, data, a notable customer, a strong expert view) and trust is part of the purchase. In Web3, AI and security it often is the purchase.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Build a 30-name media list by beat with one recent relevant article per reporter. 2. Write a one-page angle memo: why this matters to their readers this month, what is new, what proof you have. 3. Offer one reporter an exclusive or a small group an embargo, with a founder available for interviews.
METRIC TO WATCH	Pieces in target outlets that mention your positioning correctly, plus referral traffic and AI citations that follow.
COMMON MISTAKE	Mass-sending a press release to hundreds of contacts. Journalists cover stories, not announcements.

16 · Podcasts

TIME · 1 TO 3 MONTHS · DEPTH

WHEN IT FITS	The founder can hold a 45-minute conversation with specific stories and opinions. Niche shows with engaged audiences beat big generic ones.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. List 25 shows your buyers listen to (ask customers directly). 2. Pitch each host with 3 episode ideas tailored to their recent episodes, not a founder bio. 3. Clip every appearance into 3 short videos and a written recap for your own channels.
METRIC TO WATCH	Appearances per month and self-reported "heard you on a podcast" in signups.
COMMON MISTAKE	Paying for "guaranteed placement" packages on shows no buyer listens to.

17 · Influencers / KOLs

VARIES WIDELY · 1 TO 4 WEEKS · BORROWED TRUST

WHEN IT FITS	Crypto launches, consumer AI and developer tools where a handful of voices shape what an audience tries next.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Vet audiences, not follower counts: check reply quality, past sponsored posts and how those projects fared. 2. Write a brief with facts, required disclosures and things they must not say, then let them use their own voice. 3. Stagger posts in waves instead of one coordinated blast that reads as paid.
METRIC TO WATCH	Tracked signups or wallet connections per creator, via unique links or codes.
COMMON MISTAKE	Undisclosed paid promotion. It is a regulatory risk in many markets and a reputational one everywhere.

CHANNELS

Partners, events and referrals

18 · Partnerships and integrations

TIME · 2 TO 6 MONTHS · DISTRIBUTION

WHEN IT FITS	Your product sits next to a platform your buyers already use (a cloud marketplace, a chain ecosystem, a SIEM, an LLM platform).
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. List the 10 tools your best customers use alongside yours. 2. Build or polish one integration and get listed in that partner's marketplace or ecosystem page. 3. Propose one co-marketing moment: joint webinar, co-authored guide, or launch announcement.
METRIC TO WATCH	Sourced and influenced pipeline from partner listings and joint campaigns.
COMMON MISTAKE	Signing ten logo-swap partnerships with no shared customer and no follow-through.

19 · Events and conferences

\$3K TO \$50K+ · EVENT WEEK · PIPELINE

WHEN IT FITS	Enterprise, security and Web3, where key buyers, investors and reporters are all in one city for a week.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Book 15 to 25 meetings before you arrive. The booth is optional; the calendar is not. 2. Host something small and specific (a 20-person dinner, a side event) instead of sponsoring the main stage. 3. Follow up within 48 hours with notes from the conversation, not a generic deck.
METRIC TO WATCH	Qualified meetings held and pipeline created per dollar, tracked for 90 days after.
COMMON MISTAKE	Paying for a booth with no meeting plan and measuring success by badge scans.

20 · Referral programs

LOW PLUS INCENTIVES · 1 TO 3 MONTHS · COMPOUNDING

WHEN IT FITS	Customers already recommend you unprompted. A referral program amplifies word of mouth; it does not create it.
FIRST 3 ACTIONS	1. Ask for the referral at the moment of value (first successful outcome), inside the product. 2. Give both sides something that relates to the product (credits, seats, a higher tier) rather than cash where possible. 3. Make sharing one click with a prewritten message the user can edit.
METRIC TO WATCH	Share of new signups from referrals and their activation rate versus other channels.
COMMON MISTAKE	Launching before product-market fit, or rewarding signups instead of activated users, which invites fraud.

DECIDE Pick 3 channels by stage

Start with one channel you can win with founder time, one that builds credibility, and one that captures demand. Run them for eight weeks with written kill criteria before adding a fourth.

STAGE	DEFAULT 3	WHY THESE	ADD LATER
Pre-launch / pre-seed No product live, building a waitlist	LinkedIn or X (founder) · Communities · Email	Cheap, compounding, and they build the audience your launch needs. You learn the language buyers use.	Podcasts once the story is sharp
Launch First public release	PR / earned media · Product Hunt or Show HN · Email	Concentrated attention in one week. Earned coverage gives you the credibility assets every later channel reuses.	Influencers / KOLs for consumer or crypto
Seed, finding fit First 10 to 50 customers	Founder LinkedIn or X · SEO + GEO content · One paid test (Google if demand exists, LinkedIn if ACV is high)	One relationship channel, one compounding channel, one fast-feedback channel to test messages.	Partnerships, referral
Series A, scaling what works Repeatable sale in one segment	The winner from seed · PR retainer for steady credibility · Events or partnerships	Double down where CAC is proven, add channels that raise win rates and deal size.	YouTube, referral program
Token or protocol launch TGE, mainnet, major upgrade	Communities (Telegram/Discord) · X · PR in crypto-native outlets	Holders, builders and press all live in these three places. Ecosystem partners amplify on top.	KOL waves, events in major crypto weeks
Enterprise security or AI infrastructure	Founder LinkedIn · PR and analyst- style research · Events	Long cycles reward trust and named proof. A strong data report feeds all three.	LinkedIn Ads to named accounts

MY CHANNEL 1 8 WEEKS Channel, budget, owner, kill criteria 	MY CHANNEL 2 8 WEEKS Channel, budget, owner, kill criteria 	MY CHANNEL 3 8 WEEKS Channel, budget, owner, kill criteria
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● NEXT STEP

Want a senior operator *on your launch?*

Templates get you organised. Coverage, citations and pipeline come from judgement: which angle a journalist will actually take, which channel deserves the next dollar, and what to cut.

Book a 30-minute teardown. Bring your launch plan, your positioning or your last campaign and leave with a prioritised list of fixes.

Book a 30-minute teardown: shilikajain.com/contact

Six years

PR and go-to-market for Web3, AI and cybersecurity founders.

50+ protocols

Launches, funding rounds and token events supported.

Tier-1 outlets

Forbes, CoinDesk, Cointelegraph, Decrypt, The Block, Blockworks, AI Magazine.

Prefer to self-serve first? Try the free interactive planners, budget calculator and checklist at shilikajain.com/tools. More downloads live at shilikajain.com/resources.

Engagements: fractional PR retainer \$5K to \$12K per month. Launch sprint \$15K to \$40K.